

Rural medical programme expands to Taupō in 2027

The University of Auckland's Rural Medical Immersion Programme will offer fifth-year students a year-long placement in Taupō from 2027.



Taupō will become the programme's fifth year-long placement site, joining Hāwera, Hauraki/Thames, Te Kūiti and Wellsford.

The University of Auckland's Rural Medical Immersion Programme (RMIP) will expand to Taupō in 2027, creating new opportunities for medical students to train in rural healthcare settings and strengthening connections with communities across Aotearoa New Zealand.

The programme places fifth-year medical students in rural locations, where they work alongside general practitioners, rural hospital doctors and multidisciplinary teams. Students gain broad clinical experience while developing a deeper understanding of the strengths and challenges of rural medicine.

RMIP academic lead Dr Hannah Lawn says the expansion reflects the University's strong commitment to rural health training.

"The move into Taupō reflects the outstanding support of local clinicians and the wider community for growing the rural medical workforce. By immersing students in clinical practice and community life, we aim to inspire more graduates to pursue rewarding careers serving rural New Zealand."

Taupō Hospital clinical lead Dr Ralston D'Souza says the team has been preparing for the opportunity for some time.

"We are really excited to have RMIP expand to Taupō. Our team has worked hard to build a strong culture of training and pastoral care for both students and resident doctors."

He says the wider community has also played an important role, particularly by helping students find short-term accommodation. Past students have been strong advocates for bringing RMIP to Taupō.

Dr D'Souza also draws on his own experience of rural training and the long-term difference it can make.

"I completed the Whakatāne Rural Health Interprofessional Programme in 2016, and it completely changed the trajectory of my life. I grew up in Auckland and now live and work in Taupō as a rural hospital medicine specialist and GP. I hope to inspire more students to take a similar path."

University of Auckland Rural Health Unit Director and Associate Dean Rural Health, Associate Professor Kyle Eggleton, says the RMIP model has a strong track record.

"RMIP is proven to increase the likelihood that medical students will go on to become rural doctors. The Rural Health Unit is committed to building the future rural medical workforce in Aotearoa New Zealand, and we believe this initiative will help grow the number of rural doctors in Taupō."

The addition of Taupō builds on the University's long-standing commitment to rural health. Through extended placements, students develop enduring relationships with patients, clinicians and communities while gaining experience across primary, secondary and community-based care.

Source: University of Auckland, Faculty of Medical and Health Sciences